RELEVANCE OF BALANCE OF POWER

Based on the criticisms and shortcomings, Organski has asked the scholars of international relations to reject the balance of power theory because its concepts are fuzzy, it is logically unsound, full of contradictions, inconsistent with the events that have occurred, and fails to explain such events.

Richard Cobden[17] (1867) commented, “The balance of power is a chimera! It is not a fallacy, a mistake, an imposture—it is an undescribed, indescribable, incomprehensible nothing; mere words, conveying to the mind not ideas, but sounds”.

Even the rules or the basic principles propounded by the balance of power theorists are not applicable in the ever-changing scenario of international relations. For example, the principles propounded by Morton Kaplan in 1957 hardly hold today. He had prescribed how the statesmen should or ought to behave rather than how they actually behave. Further, his rule 6, “treat all major powers as acceptable partners” is hardly tenable because, in the present context, given the importance of public opinion and a simultaneous increase in nationalism, it is not possible for a state to ally with another disregarding these restraining factors. Further, during the Cold War it was witnessed that ideological differences delayed the rapprochement between the United States and China for long.

Neither of the rules seems to be valid in contemporary international relations. A total all-out war now might lead to extremes and any unsuccessful venture might lead to loss of popular support as happened in the case of US during the Vietnam War. Moreover, if public opinion swings between interventionism and isolationism, it becomes difficult for a state to oppose a dangerously growing opponent. There can also be a system change without a great war as it had occurred in the Soviet Union.

Moreover, the spread of weapons of mass destruction, for example, the nuclear weapons, has created situations which are quite different from the pre-nuclear international scenario. The possession of nuclear weapons may work as a deterrent and induce the leaders to use the force with restraint and prevent escalation of small wars to